Three Common Sticking Points When Families Start Organizing Mom's Finances

What each one looks like, why it happens, and a better habit for each.

Families tend to stall in the same three places when they start on a parent's finances. None of them is anyone's fault, and each has a small habit that gets things moving again.

1 Hunting through scattered paper

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The bank statements are in the desk, the insurance policy is in a folder in the hall closet, the pension letter comes by email, and the deed is “somewhere safe.” Each time you sit down to start, the afternoon goes to looking.

WHY IT HAPPENS Paper arrives one piece at a time over decades, and each piece was put where it made sense that day. AARP describes the same thing: records in random order, or stored in different, perhaps forgotten, places. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Before moving anything, write down where each paper is now. Then agree with Mom on one place for the ones that matter most. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau suggests a safe, easily accessible location, and letting a trusted person know where to find it. [2]

2 Knowing roughly, not exactly

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE You know there's a pension, a checking account and the house. Asked what arrives each month, or whether there was ever a second bank, you'd be guessing.

WHY IT HAPPENS You've never needed to know. Mom has always handled it, and it's hers. Rough knowledge was enough for everything the family has had to do so far.

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask her, one category at a time, and write down what she says: income, accounts, investments, property, insurance, debts and regular expenses. The bureau's guide for people who help with a relative's money says that to make careful decisions you need to know what the person owns and owes, and AARP offers plain questions to borrow, such as “At which banks do you have accounts?” and “Do you own life insurance?” Where neither of you knows, write “don't know yet.” [3] [1]

3 Trying to work out what matters for Medicaid

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Halfway down the list you start sorting. This probably counts, that probably doesn't, no need to write down the car. Or the list stalls because you're not sure it's the “right” one.

WHY IT HAPPENS It's a reasonable thing to want to know. But a federal overview says the assessment of a person's assets can be fairly complex, depending on how much and what kind of assets they have, and Medicare.gov sends people to their own state's Medicaid office for eligibility information. It isn't something a family can settle at the kitchen table. [4] [5]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write it all down and leave the sorting out. Keep a second page for questions as they come up, and bring both pages to your Medicaid planner.

The one habit behind all three

Write down what exists and where its paper is kept. Leave what it means to a professional who knows your state.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say which of Mom's finances matter for Medicaid or what to do about any of them, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. It names three sticking points, which are the same three the Medicaid Planning Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know where families stall and the habit that helps with each. The planning interview picks up from your list: it asks about your family's situation one question at a time and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The description of scattered records, the advice on where to keep papers, the questions to borrow and the two general statements about Medicaid come from the sources below. The three sticking points are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. AARP, 5 Steps to Organize Your Loved One's Financial Records
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid Eligibility
5. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?

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